

Networks among Right-Wing Populist Heads of State: Qualitative and Statistical Evidence

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Abstract

Across the globe, right-wing populist leaders have registered a wave of electoral successes since the mid-2010s, coming to govern countries as diverse as the United States, India, Brazil, Hungary, Italy, and Argentina. This paper asks whether these leaders draw on a common rhetorical repertoire or instead articulate nationally specific projects, and what their speeches reveal about the transnational organization of the contemporary far right. We combine process tracing of leaders meetings and organizational ties with automated text analysis of an original corpus of all public speeches delivered in office by six right-wing populist heads of government (Donald Trump, Narendra Modi, Jair Bolsonaro, Viktor Orban, Giorgia Meloni, and Javier Milei) in their original languages. Using multilingual sentence embeddings and topic models, we map each leaders rhetoric into a shared semantic space and construct cross-leader similarity networks that recover the community structure of shared themes. Substantively, we find a clear family resemblance in the rhetoric of right-wing populist leaders, centered on nationalism, cultural and religious conservatism, and anti-elite, anti-globalist frames. The similarity networks reveal a tightly knit core bloc whose thematic clusters are densely interconnected, alongside more peripheral leaders whose rhetoric overlaps only selectively with this shared repertoire. The process-tracing evidence shows that these rhetorical affinities are not merely parallel responses to common shocks but are associated with over a decade of intensive personal contact, shared conferences, and institution-building among a subset of leaders. Taken together, the qualitative and quantitative evidence support an interpretation of the global far right as an actively coordinated transnational movement rather than a set of independent national trajectories.

Introduction

Across the globe, right-wing populist leaders have experienced a series of electoral victories since the mid-2010s, coming to govern more than two billion people in countries as diverse as the United States, India, and Brazil. The rise of these leaders, such as Donald Trump, Narendra Modi, and Jair Bolsonaro, has been remarkable because despite the vast differences in the contemporary characteristics and historical development of their countries, they have often emphasized similar issues, used similar framings, and seemed to echo each others broader themes. They have stood out sharply not only from their rivals on the left and center left, but also from previous iterations of the right and center right in their respective countries and regions, and they appear to have worked together, both openly and in quieter ways, to bring about their shared vision. To supporters and opponents, they represent a global wave, on par with previous waves of democratization and autocratization (Huntington, 1991; Lührmann and Lindberg, 2019; Diamond, 2015, 2022) and ideological trends like the pink tide of the 2000s in Latin America (Levitsky and Roberts, 2011).

Why have right-wing populists gained power across so many different contexts at the same time? A wide range of research across the social sciences has attempted to describe and explain the common characteristics and causes of their electoral successes (Rydgren, 2007; Golder, 2016; Arzheimer, 2018; Rodrik, 2021; Berman, 2021). In particular, a large literature has developed in political science assessing the individual- level and country-level predictors of support for far right parties and movements in western Europe (Ignazi, 1992; Kitschelt, 1997; Norris, 2005; Mudde, 2007; Art, 2006, 2011; De Vries and Hobolt, 2020; Valentim, 2024b), and high-profile work has situated Trumpism and the Brexit referendum in comparative perspective (Norris and Inglehart, 2017, 2019; Gest, 2016; Gest, Reny and Mayer, 2018; Mudde and Kaltwasser, 2017; Mudde and Rovira Kaltwasser, 2018; Mudde, 2019; Hawkins et al., 2019; Hawkins and Littvay, 2019). Explanations have included demand-side theories emphasizing the impact of economic globalization, migration, or cultural change on voting behavior and supply-side approaches focusing on features of political communication, social norms, and activist organizations. Yet the appeal of right-wing populism has expanded well beyond western Europe and the United States since 2016, and the factors elevating far right leaders to executive office around the world today might be different than the factors that fueled the emergence or breakthrough of their parties and movements.

To better understand this important development in contemporary global politics, we use a mixed-methods approach that combines process tracing and automated text analysis to point towards new hypotheses and suggest promising areas for future study. First, by identifying causal process observations, we begin to adjudicate between competing theories that right- wing populist leaders have either collaborated on central elements of strategy and tactics or developed their approaches to electoral politics independently. From close reading of press releases, news coverage, and investigative reporting about their contacts and meetings over the past decade, we conclude that it is more likely that right-wing populist leaders have cooperated at a high level, actively engaging in message borrowing and sharing rhetorical frameworks to best position their parties and movements electorally. Second, we introduce a novel dataset of all the public speeches of six right-wing populist leaders during their time in executive office, scraped from government transcripts in their native languages. We use a multilinguistic version of dynamic topic modeling, built with untranslated text from the Google corpus, to get a more accurate picture of what these leaders discuss, when they discuss it, and how they relate to each other. We find that there is meaningful similarity between the topics and clusters of topics that these leaders discuss and between the speeches of the leaders overall, particularly Jair Bolsonaro, Javier Milei, Giorgia Meloni, and Viktor Orban.

Empirically, we provide the first comprehensive analysis of rhetoric by right-wing populist leaders in executive office. We add to a growing literature placing Trumps speeches and the speeches of other far right leaders in comparative and historical perspective (Hawkins and Kaltwasser, 2018; Jenne, Hawkins and Silva, 2021; McDonnell and Ondelli, 2022, 2025; Savin and Treisman, 2025). Yet prior work has relied upon quota sampling, selecting illustrative examples, or narrowing the time span under study to manage the large number of speeches that each leader gives, and it has often focused on comparing left-wing and right-wing leaders or included both government and opposition party leaders, who have a different set of incentives in their rhetoric (Noble, 2024). This paper focuses on comparing right-wing populist leaders with each other

during their time in power to see what they have in common and what distinguishes them and considers all speeches that they gave since they began to win elections around the world in the mid-2010s. We offer a complement to existing research that has drawn upon comprehensive datasets of Trumps rhetoric and compared it with past presidents (e.g. Jordan et al. 2019; Zhou et al. 2024), situating Trump in the broader global context of right-wing populists in power. We also build upon recent qualitative work that has explicitly compared the rhetorical strategies of several right-wing populist leaders, including how Trump and Orban hijack victimhood (Hronešová and Kreiss, 2024) and how Trump and Bolsonaro framed the COVID-19 pandemic (Béland et al., 2021).

Theoretically, this paper extends this work and other work suggesting a process of mutual learning among far right leaders (Rydgren, 2005; de Lange and Art, 2011; Abrahamsen and Williams, 2023) as well as new scholarship interested in ideological importation on the contemporary right from the United States to other countries (Asher and Mandelkern, 2025) and posits that network variables and multidimensional relationships are necessary to describe and explain the process by which right-wing populist leaders have coordinated on messaging across national borders over the past decade. Like American and western European efforts during the Cold War and the neoliberal era to spread capitalist and liberal democratic ideas (Dezalay and Garth, 2002; Schimmelfennig, 2001; Ban, 2016; Keck and Sikkink, 1998), far right leaders today have marshaled both state institutions and global networks of think tanks, policy experts, advocacy organizations, and media companies to develop and advance their ideological project. They have worked to define the core beliefs and key demarcation points underlying their rhetorical frameworks, and they have accumulated and deployed resources to disseminate their common worldview.

With qualitative insights from their contacts and meetings and quantitative evidence from an original database of their speeches, we hope to make two contributions to the literature on right-wing populism. First, to account for the global wave of far right electoral victories, we argue that political science needs an explanatory agenda that is global as well. Building upon previous efforts to broaden the scope of scholarship, including by extending coverage to Latin America (Pereira, 2023; Zanotti and Roberts, 2021; Zanotti, 2024; Borges and Zanotti, 2025), considering other cases in the Global South and outside the West (Buřtková, 2018; Bustikova, 2019; Kaltwasser and Zanotti, 2023; Pinheiro-Machado and Vargas-Maia, 2023; Higuchi, 2018), and beginning to debate is the far right a global phenomenon? (de Jonge et al., 2024), this paper presents new evidence that approaches limited to a single country or region are failing to ask essential questions. Right-wing populist causes and candidates have repeatedly exceeded expectations of their geographic limits and exhibited growing electoral appeal across a wide variety of contexts. They have crossed regional boundaries and matched or overtaken left-wing forms of populism where more inclusionary populist leaders had previously predominated (Mudde and Kaltwasser, 2012, 2013).

Second, in addition to a thoroughly global lens, we argue that an explicitly transnational one is needed to explain the rise of right-wing populism around the world. In doing so, this paper takes note from social movements scholarship which has long observed networked ties among right-wing extremists in person (Caiani, 2018; Porta, Caiani and Wagemann, 2012; Caiani, 2025) and online (Caiani and Kröll, 2015; Heft et al., 2021; Heft, Reinhardt and Pfetsch, 2022; Bennett and Livingston, 2025; Livingston and Miller, 2025), international relations work theorizing a counter-hegemonic project (Wojczewski, 2024; Adler-Nissen and Zarakol, 2021) and locating its roots in the imperial past (Valdez, 2022), and evidence of contagion effects following far right electoral victories (Giani and Meon, 2021; Turnbull-Dugarte and Rama, 2022; Roumanias, Rori and Georgiadou, 2022). We show that though domestic conditions are part of the causal story, they are not enough to understand the recent electoral successes of right-wing populists, and we urge caution against modeling far right electoral victories as independent events.

Synthesizing arguments for global and transnational approaches and challenging scholars to more consistently employ them together, we outline a new direction for research on right-wing populism. Our mixed-methods approach highlights the importance and utility of redoubling efforts to take a wider view and investigate networked relationships in studies of the contemporary far right.

We will argue, on the basis of both the qualitative and quantitative evidence, that there is compelling

reason to believe that the populist right wing is marked by a clear cross-national network, but also that the network's properties are not stable over time. Nor does this network cleanly replicate the structures of existing international power relations. Instead, leaders of relatively peripheral countries (especially Brazil's Bolsonaro and Hungary's Orban) emerge as crucial organizational entrepreneurs and central nodes in networks. These roles first appear after Bolsonaro's election, in 2018, and become more pronounced following the social, economic, and political dislocations of the pandemic in 2020. Understanding the timing, political geography, and opportunity structure of the transnational network underlying the global surge of nationalist, populist right-wing movements stands as an important scholarly opportunity.

Case Selection

We are interested in studying the population of leaders that together form the apparent recent wave of right-wing disruptions of the political status quo, which scholars have discussed as right-wing populists (Rodrik, 2021), the far right (Golder, 2016; Mudde, 2019), ethnonationalists (Thompson, 2021), and so forth. We are using the category of right-wing populists, which combines two theoretical strands to highlight what we see as a trend worth studying.

First, we are interested in right-wing leaders. This means we are not simply interested in outsiders, disruptors, or populists in general. Nor are we interested in garden-variety conservatives or center-right politicians. We want to focus on politicians who have an ideological stance that is toward the right in a way that has a more militant edge, typically with a vision of a transformed rather than maintained society.

The ideal type of a right-wing leader in our conceptualization stands apart from a conservative/center-right politician or from an opportunistic populist because the right-wing leader consistently deploys reactionary and often anti-democratic ideological messages (Pirro, 2023). For example, a right-wing leader may frequently echo the anti-communist/anti-socialist messaging of the John Birch Society (Mulloy, 2014) and other right-wing movements of the Cold War era. Alternatively, a right-wing leader may emphasize overt ethnonationalist messages (Thompson, 2021), or conspiratorial ideations drawn from an ideological framework such as QAnon (Bleakley, 2023). A conservative or center-right politician would tend to avoid these kinds of themes, preferring a focus on less inflammatory appeals or pragmatic policy proposals. An opportunistic populist may occasionally seize on reactionary messages but would drop them when the situation changes and would not maintain them as a long-term consistent theme.

Second, we are interested in populists (Hawkins and Kaltwasser, 2017; Hawkins et al., 2019; Mudde and Kaltwasser, 2017). This means, among other things, that we seek leaders who cultivate a high level of tension with both the preexisting domestic and international orders in the name of cultivating the true voice of the neglected people (Canovan, 1999). A populist leader, on our way of seeing things, sees many existing democratic and other institutions as an unnecessary roadblock preventing the right decisions that will represent the will of the people. As such, populists are eager to sidestep long-established norms, organizations, rules of the game, parties, and democratic standards if doing so enhances their power and therefore their ability to implement what they describe as the obvious popular will.

Specifically, we are looking for leaders whose political careers create major disruptions in their societies' party systems, regime norms and/or systems of ethnic relations, as these three areas appear to be salient among the major institutional domains disrupted by populism in contemporary experience.

The ideal type of a right-wing populist, given our conceptual framework, is a leader who substantially disrupts many major institutional systems in a society while also frequently emphasizing messages of anti-communism, ethnonationalism, and conspiratorial ideology. Victor Orban may be something close to the best empirical approximation of this ideal type. Orban's political career began during a time when Hungary was emerging from literal communism, and his roots are in actual anti-communism; thus, anti-communist ideology is far from foreign to him. However, the fact that he still discusses anti-communism in the current era is perhaps more surprising, and more so the fact that he describes his centrist opposition as the new

communists: “everyone knows that in Western Europe it is natural for the liberals to be the new communists” (Orbán, 2023).

This is the kind of contemporary anti-communist ideology that marks a politician as right-wing. Furthermore, Orbán frequently promotes ethnonationalism. For example, in a 2022 speech, Orbán said Hungarians “are not mixed-race: we are simply a mixture of peoples living in our own European homeland... we are willing to mix with one another, but we do not want to become peoples of mixed-race” (Orbán, 2022). Finally, Orbán is notoriously willing to traffic in conspiratorial messages, promoting notions of a global “LGBTQ offensive” or “propaganda” movement and hypothesizing that George Soros is behind an unrealistic number of events and organizations.

Orbán is also a leader who has dramatically changed the democratic norms and rules of Hungary, repeatedly, through his party’s supermajority control of the country’s legislature and resulting ability to rewrite the constitution at will. He likewise manipulates Hungary’s party system freely, leading the creation of hundreds of shell parties with names resembling major opposition movements to confuse voters in addition to his defining transformation of fundamentally redirecting many of the programmatic and ideological commitments of his own, initially pro-democracy, party, Fidesz. Finally, Orbán has advocated a major increase in tension between Hungarian identity and the identities of various outgroups (Muslim immigrants, non-Hungarian Europeans, Jews) in a way that is quite likely to have done work to reshape the system of ethnic politics in the country.

Thus, Orbán fulfills, to at least some meaningful extent, all three variants of each of the two dimensions involved in our conceptualization of a right-wing populist. He is a reasonable approximation of the ideal type; most other real-world examples will tend not to meet all the criteria to this same extent. While we see right-wing populism among leaders as a radial concept, with the ideal type at the center and real-world examples differing from the ideal type in a variety of ways, we are willing to include in our population any leaders who meet at least one of the criteria related to ideological messages and one of the criteria related to tensions with existing institutional orders.

This is in contrast to someone like 1980s British prime minister Margaret Thatcher, who certainly had a strong anti-communist message (although such a message was less unusual and ideologically disruptive in a time period when major world powers were still actively promoting communism than it is today) but who largely worked within the existing British political regime framework. We can also rule out left-leaning populists like Evo Morales, who transform the institutional framework of their societies but who advance visions of ethnic pluralism and do not embrace right-wing conspiracies or anti-communism.

For our purposes, existing definitions fall short in two ways. First, definitions developed from close study of the far right in western Europe, where the majority of research on the recent wave of right-wing populist electoral victories has taken place, run the risk of imputing features particular to rich democracies, the West, or the Global North. Even the most careful definitions designed to travel beyond western Europe might overemphasize attributes like nativism in contexts in which there are fewer migrants or “non-native elements” are not as consistently seen to pose a threat (Mudde, 2007; Art, 2022). Without greater access to data to fully turn towards techniques from unsupervised machine learning to identify global right-wing populist clusters (Golder, 2016), offering a new conceptualization of global right-wing populism can help to minimize regional biases.

Second, definitions intended to be global have too often failed to distinguish sharply between left-wing and right-wing populism or limit their scope to full and flawed democratic contexts. Leading theoretical and empirical approaches to populism have sometimes grouped left-wing populist leaders like Hugo Chavez together with Donald Trump, Jair Bolsonaro, and Victor Orbán (Muller 2016, Norris and Inglehart 2019). The combination effectively highlights the similarities between distinct trajectories of contemporary political development but tends to obscure more than it reveals about the rise of right-wing populism in particular.

Authoritarian leaders like Nicolas Maduro, Abdel Fattah El-Sisi, or Vladimir Putin likewise fit poorly with the phenomenon of right-wing populist electoral successes that we are attempting to explain. Though we

are sensitive that right-wing populism can become popular in both democratic and nondemocratic contexts (Tuñal, 2021), we believe that including its forms that justify autocratic rule creates new challenges and moves us away from our goal of better understanding the sources of right-wing populist voting. We hope that the inclusion of several cases from flawed democracies in our empirical work helps to break down overly formal binaries between democracies and nondemocracies in political science and shed light on other flawed democratic contexts like Recep Tayyip Erdoğan’s Turkey.

Literature Review

While there remains robust debate about how to conceptualize right-wing populist movements, researchers in political science, economics, communications, and other fields have been drawn towards explaining why these movements seem to be taking place across so many contexts at the same time.

Existing explanations have generally fallen into two broad categories: demand-side theories that center the role of mass publics in responding to economic, social, and technological developments like globalization, post-materialism, and the Internet, and supply-side theories that focus upon the parts played by political elites in raising the salience of issues through framing or priming and opening (von Beyme, 1988; Mudde, 2007; Rydgren, 2007; Berman, 2021).

Yet though there is no shortage of theorizing based on country-level and region-level findings, few studies have adopted a truly global and transnational lens. In light of the apparently global nature of the phenomenon and suggestive evidence of collaboration across borders, we argue that there needs to be a global and transnational explanatory agenda in work on right-wing populism. Building upon recent findings from a large secondary literature, we use causal process observations from contacts and meetings between incumbent right-wing populist leaders and text data from their speeches to suggest that global and transnational networks and activist organizations have been underexplored as a source of right-wing populist electoral success.

Demand-Side Explanations: Globalization and Cultural Backlash

The most prominent explanations in the existing literature tend to be focused upon the responses of mass publics to intensifying processes of economic globalization. As demand-side theories, they have used analysis of national election surveys and public opinion polling to study the correlates of right-wing populist voting at the individual level, and hypothesized trade, financial crises, and inequality as the driving factors. While they may help to identify important variables in specific countries or regions, they often leave much of the cross-national variation unexplained, including why some countries turn towards right-wing populists and other countries do not under similar circumstances.

Economic Globalization: Trade, Financial Crises, and Inequality

The strongest evidence of demand-side forces at work in specific countries and regions has arguably come from economists interested in economic globalization. Operationalizing economic globalization through trade shocks, scholars have demonstrated that there are political consequences of trade. Particularly with “the China trade shock,” they have found increased rates of voting for right-wing populist candidates and parties in affected areas in western Europe, the United States, and Latin America (Autor et al., 2017, 2020; Choi et al., 2024; Malgouyres, 2017; Colantone and Stanig, 2018a,b; Baccini and Weymouth, 2021; Campello and Urdinez, 2021; Costa, Junior and Rocha, 2023). Republican presidential candidate Donald Trump, the Leave campaign in the Brexit referendum, the National Front in France, and Pentecostal congressional candidates in Brazil are among the political actors who have benefited, leaving behind distinctive patterns of electoral support.

Other ways that researchers have attempted to operationalize economic globalization in evaluating its contributions towards right-wing populist electoral success include financial crises and economic inequality and insecurity in general.

Financial crises, for example, have been shown to motivate right-wing populist voting, with the 2008 financial crisis in particular often positioned as having laid the groundwork for right-wing populist movements in the

mid-2010s (Funke, Schularick and Trebesch, 2016; Gyngysi and Verner, 2022; Ahlquist, Copelovitch and Walter, 2020; Mian, Sufi and Trebbi, 2014). However, accounts focusing on the responses of voters to financial crises are troubled by the fact that a similar set of factors have been used in the past to explain socialist or left-leaning populist movements, like the “pink tide” in Latin America, which scholars traced to the 1998-2002 economic crisis (Levitsky and Roberts, 2011; Panizza and Yaşez, 2005). Behind the difficulty is a larger unresolved puzzle of why voters believe right-wing populism is the solution at all. If voters want disruption to the status quo of financial crises, then why are other sorts of disruption, such as left-wing populism or radical technocratic movements, not pursued more often?

One answer comes from emerging evidence from Latin America that voters may have turned towards right-wing populist movements because of dissatisfaction with how left-wing populist governments handled economic downturns in the past, especially in Brazil (Nam, 2015; Junge, 2019; Pinheiro-Machado and Scalco, 2020). The connection of left-wing populists to a prolonged crisis may have been discrediting, whereas right-wing populists may have benefited from being perceived as offering a new approach. Yet at the same time, right-wing populists have not always been discredited by their mismanagement of financial crises or their connections to the political past. Scholars of politics in western Europe have even theorized that opposition to globalization has been channeled through right-wing populist parties because they were established first and their legacies of mobilization undercut potential support from rivals when faced with challenges (Kriesi and Grande, 2012).

Beyond boom-and-bust cycles, researchers have also considered the political effects of economic inequality and insecurity more generally. While the consequences of a widening gap are difficult to measure, political scientists have theorized that a new political cleavage between the “winners” and “losers” of economic globalization has opened up across contexts, layered over long-standing cleavages of class, religion, and ethnicity (Betz, 1993, 1994; Kitschelt, 1997; Kriesi et al., 2006, 2008; Rydgren, 2013; Hooghe and Marks, 2018). The causal story is that economic globalization has advantaged some mass publics and disadvantaged others, and the distributive consequences have been strong enough to create and sustain a division among voters.

Together, the demand-side explanations centered around the responses of mass publics to economic globalization have offered both specific operationalizations of variables of interest like trade shocks and financial crises as well as more general theoretical frameworks like the opening of a cleavage between “winners” and “losers.” While the evidence ranges from cross-national regression studies to a variety of instrumental variables approaches, they place the focus on changes in the global economy, a plausible starting point for investigations of the rise of right-wing populist voting worldwide.

Challenges for accounts centering economic globalization include mixed empirical evidence in the most recent review essays and meta-analyses and difficulty with explaining finer patterns of country-level variation (Amengay and Stockemer, 2019; Walter, 2021; Berman, 2021; Guriev and Papaioannou, 2022; Scheiring et al., 2024). But even if bottom-up responses to globalization did represent a more compelling explanation for right-wing populist voting worldwide, it is not clear why people would have turned to the right instead of the left, which has its own competing tradition of skepticism toward globalization (van Elsas and van der Brug, 2015; van Elsas, Hakhverdian and van der Brug, 2016).

Cultural Backlash: Cleavages, Cohorts, and Culture War Issues

While maintaining a focus on mass publics, cultural backlash explanations make progress towards untangling why people have shifted right instead of left. Centering the responses of older cohorts of voters to the rise in post-materialist values among younger generations, cultural backlash theories tend to highlight reactions against changes to long-standing gender, racial, and religious hierarchies that resulted from the social movements of the 1950s, 1960s, and 1970s. Encompassing post hoc opposition to political developments as diverse as the women’s movement, the LGBTQ+ rights movement, decolonization, the civil rights movement, secularization, urbanization, and democratization, the cultural backlash literature highlights how shifts among voters have realigned electoral politics around new cleavages.

The seminal piece on the opening of a new cleavage that advantaged right-wing populist movements is Piero Ignazi’s 1992 article “The silent counter-revolution.” Building upon earlier research from Ronald Inglehart and others that identified a “silent revolution” in the rise of post-materialist values (Inglehart, 1971, 1977; Flanagan, 1979, 1982a; Inglehart, 1982; Flanagan, 1982b; Inglehart and Flanagan, 1987; Minkenberg and Inglehart, 1989), Ignazi argued that an increase in right-wing values among the mass public had subsequently occurred, with both center-right and right-wing populist parties benefiting (Ignazi, 1992). A cultural cleavage, rather than an economic cleavage organized around processes of industrialization or globalization, had come to divide voters who embraced the changes to the hierarchies of the mid-twentieth century and voters who opposed them.

The basic logic from Ignazi’s 1992 article has since been developed and extended beyond its original scope. Scholars have differentiated the cultural cleavage from a simple divide between the winners and losers of modernization, clarified its timing and sequence, and conceptualized it as a newly salient axis of conflict between people with “libertarian-universalistic” values and people with “traditionalist-communitarian” values (Minkenberg, 2000; Ignazi, 2003; Flanagan and Lee, 2003; Bornschier, 2010b,a, 2018). These advances have underlined efforts to transport the framework beyond western Europe, including Pippa Norris and Ronald Inglehart’s *Cultural Backlash*. A definitive statement of demand-side thinking, *Cultural Backlash* considers examples of “authoritarian populism” on the right, but it shares the focus on the reaction of mass publics to the rise in post-materialist values that has animated the literature since the 1990s (Norris and Inglehart, 2019). It locates the source of political developments that have brought the right to power in a series of value changes at the individual level that began with the social movements of the 1950s, 1960s, and 1970s.

The argument is not too different from ones made by both center-right and right-wing populist politicians, and it has forerunners in classic work in history and American politics, but it has been sharpened in recent years (Lassiter, 2006; Key Jr., 1949; Edsall and Edsall, 1992). Historical public opinion work, for example, has shown that mass publics in the United States diverged over the civil rights movement, and racially conservative voters brought conservative views on “culture war” issues like abortion with them into the Republican coalition when they realigned, changing the conditions under which Republican politicians sought office (O’Brian, 2024; Schickler, 2016; Hood III, Kidd and Morris, 2012; Maxwell and Shields, 2019). More contemporarily, experimental studies have shown that the stacking of partisan, racial, religious, and ideological identities in the mass public has strengthened us-versus-them dynamics (Mason, 2015, 2018; Mason and Wronski, 2018; Kinder and Sanders, 1996; Kinder and Kam, 2009; Tesler, 2016; Abramowitz, 2018; Jardina, 2019; Hajnal, 2020; Finkel et al., 2020).

While research on mass-level partisan polarization and the development of a cultural cleavage in the party system is still relatively new to the Global South, there is some evidence suggesting that news about cultural issues, particularly topics concerning gender and sexuality like abortion, same-sex marriage, and transgender rights, can reduce the importance of economic issues in Latin America (Smith and Boas, 2024; Inglehart and Welzel, 2005; Gaskins, Golder and Siegel, 2013; Bargsted and De La Cerda, 2019). In activist and influencer spaces, right-wing economic and cultural messages have even been intricately woven together, breaking down the distinction between economic and cultural dimensions (Ravecca et al., 2023). The conclusion from analysis of social media data in Latin America is similar to the takeaway from the debate in American politics that began with Thomas Frank’s *What’s the Matter with Kansas?* over why many working and middle class people vote against their own economic interests. While it may appear like people are prioritizing cultural issues at the expense of economic issues, ethnographic work before and after the 2016 election shows that right-wing populist movements have tapped into feelings that tend to combine dimensions like “rural resentment” and “stolen pride” (Cramer, 2016; Gest, 2016; Hochschild, 2016, 2024).

Yet while the empirical basis of cultural backlash theories is clear and convincing, as explanations of right-wing populist movements they tend to miss important earlier processes in the causal chain, capturing only a snapshot of what is happening towards the end of the relevant sequence of events. Like theories focusing on responses to economic globalization, they have an inherent endogeneity problem, which may be especially worrisome for understanding the rise of candidates and parties that highlight cultural issues. Though political

elites do not often need to raise economic issues for voters to connect them to electoral politics, voters do not organically come to see cultural issues as urgent problems. They do not tend to factor them into their voting without entrepreneurial efforts to construct the issues and mobilize constituencies around them.

Bringing the supply side into efforts to explain the electoral success of right-wing populist movements, therefore, can not only uncover crucial causal processes by going further back in the causal chain and looking at a wider range of political actors. It can also continue to sharpen accounts of why right-wing populist movements have succeeded in some places but not others, particularly with attitudes towards cultural issues like abortion or immigration being very stable in the aggregate.

Supply-Side Explanations: Political Elites and Activists

The most established way to incorporate the role of the supply side and political elites into accounts of rising right-wing populism has been to highlight the effects of priming, framing, and agenda setting by candidates and parties. The evidence from political scientists and communication scholars is strong that right-wing populists have been able to increase the salience of issues that benefit them, discuss events in ways that boost their support, and introduce new dimensions of conflict that reshape the party system. Sometimes, other political actors like the news media and rival political parties have even unintentionally or opportunistically worked to advantage right-wing populists.

Yet other, often complementary, ways of thinking about the influence of political elites in large processes of political development remain underexplored, particularly how frames originate and how agendas are constructed. If the political communication literature captures how political elites interact with voters, more work is needed to step back in the causal chain and analyze how political elites interact with each other. By studying relationships and strategic calculations among leaders as an independent variable, research can reveal how messages are developed, and how networks are assembled to disseminate them. Ultimately, these more historical and institutionalist approaches focusing on the importance of organizations among political elites can help to gain leverage on explaining why right-wing populist leaders have emerged in some contexts but not others.

Political Communication: Priming, Framing, and Agenda Setting

The earliest efforts to theorize the role of the supply side and political elites revolved around identifying a “winning formula” in the policy positions of right-wing populist candidates and parties in western Europe (Kitschelt, 1997). Grounded in rationale from spatial models that parties have an incentive to diverge in ideological space, these efforts argued that right-wing populists needed to adopt free market libertarian positions on economic issues and authoritarian positions on social issues in order to succeed electorally, but faced empirical challenges. Researchers in particular showed that many successful right-wing populist parties had welfare chauvinist rather than free market libertarian positions on economic issues, and the convergence of center-right parties did not always help right-wing populists (Mudde, 1999, 2000; Lubbers, 2001; Minkenberg, 1997; Schain, 1997; Abedi, 2002; Carter, 2005; Spies and Franzmann, 2011; Norris, 2005; Bustikova, 2014). Variation across countries has proved to be too complex, even within western Europe, for explanations that center policy positions.

Scholars have subsequently shifted their focus to political communication effects like priming, framing, and partisan cueing, particularly by right-wing populists themselves. Building upon research showing that parties can manipulate the salience of issues that favor them, scholars of western Europe have argued that Euroskeptic political elites offered clear and consistent cues that mass publics took (De Vries and Edwards, 2009; Gabel and Scheve, 2007; Ray, 2003; Steenbergen and Jones, 2002; Hutter and Kriesi, 2022). The large literature on partisan polarization and sorting in the United States has likewise converged around a similar theoretical takeaway: the messaging of political elites has been key in bringing about polarization and sorting, with specific kinds of Republicans taking the lead in the early years (Hacker and Pierson, 2005; Rohde, 1991; Theriault, 2008; Theriault and Rohde, 2011; Theriault, 2013; Lee, 2016; Grossman and Hopkins, 2016; Hetherington, 2001; Hetherington and Weiler, 2009; Levendusky, 2009, 2010; ?; Barber and Pope, 2019; Newman et al., 2021). By providing cues on issues like crime and framing other issues like

spending in new ways, right-wing populist candidates and elected officials inside the Republican coalition might have constructed a durable constituency for right-wing populism over time.

Besides their strategic political communication on existing issues, right-wing populists can also act as “political entrepreneurs” and play a major role in agenda-setting by introducing new or previously ignored issues like immigration and opening up new dimensions of conflict (De Vries and Hobolt, 2012, 2015; ?). Many right-wing populist parties in western Europe have found electoral success with a single-minded focus on immigration, positioning themselves in stark contrast with mainstream parties. Scholars of legislative politics have similarly argued that immigration is a “wedge issue” in the United States that divided the Republican coalition originally assembled by Ronald Reagan, and they have predicted since the late 2000s that the Republicans would become increasingly populist (Jeong et al., 2011; Miller and Schofield, 2008).

Yet beyond the deliberate efforts of right-wing populists themselves, other theoretical approaches contend that moderate Republicans in the United States and mainstream parties in western Europe might have inadvertently contributed to the growth of their right-wing populist rivals through their own political communication strategies. Using the concept of issue ownership, Bonnie Meguid shows that mainstream parties can unintentionally help niche parties by raising the salience of issues that niche parties own (Meguid, 2005, 2008; Budge and Farlie, 1983; Petrocik, 1996). More recent work on western Europe refines the theory and adds compelling evidence that center-right parties and even some center-left parties like the Social Democrats in Sweden have facilitated rising right-wing populism, including by increasing awareness of their issues and “mainstreaming” their positions (Bale, 2003, 2018; Dahlström and Sundell, 2012; Krause, Cohen and Abou-Chadi, 2023; Katsambekis, 2023).

Finally, in choosing which issues to cover and how to cover them, the news media can advantage or disadvantage right-wing populist parties and candidates (McCombs and Shaw, 1972; Iyengar and Kinder, 1987; Scheufele and Tewksbury, 2007). Researchers have found, for example, that changes in the amount and type of coverage of issues “owned” by right-wing populists like immigration over time are highly predictive of changes in public opinion on the issue (Boomgaarden and Vliegenthart, 2007, 2009; Koopmans and Muis, 2009). The results are consistent with multiple different bodies of literature, from experimental findings showing framing effects in the coverage of illegal immigration in the United States (Haynes, Merolla and Ramakrishnan, 2016) to comparative historical studies documenting that tabloids can shape the trajectory of right-wing populist parties and candidates through the nature of their interventions into public debates (Art, 2006). In addition to the growing amount of work from historians and political scientists on the effects of right-wing media (Hemmer, 2016; Noel, 2013; Jamieson and Cappella, 2010; Grossman, Margalit and Mitts, 2022; DellaVigna and Kaplan, 2007; Martin and Yurukoglu, 2017) and emerging efforts to isolate social media effects (Robertson, Shariff and Bavel, 2024; Robertson, del Rosario and Bavel, 2024), there are clear indicators that elements of the news media have fueled the rise of right-wing populism in many countries.

Bringing together the entrepreneurial efforts of right-wing populists and the unforeseen consequences of strategic behavior by other political actors, the most comprehensive frameworks for understanding the rise of right-wing populist parties and candidates often suggest that these political processes compound upon each other. From elite interviews and content analysis, David Art sketches that the outcomes of “public debates” involving both the news media and politicians across the ideological spectrum have far-reaching implications, including the development of a cordon sanitaire against right-wing populist parties and candidates (Art, 2006). More recently, Vicente Valentim has extensively documented with experimental work how the normalization of right-wing populist voting and other forms of political expression occur, revealing the power of social norm change at the societal level (Valentim, 2024b; Dinas, Martinez and Valentim, 2024; Valentim, 2024a). Despite employing different methodologies, both agree that societal expectations as constructed by existing political elites condition the supply side of right-wing populism.

Yet supply-side theories focusing on the effects of public debate and political communication miss the crucial role of global and transnational networks, including but not limited to those involving political elites. We add new evidence from analysis of text data that shows patterns of clustering in the rhetoric of far right leaders,

suggesting that global and transnational linkages and message sharing represent a supply-side explanation that has not received due investigation.

Organizations: Global and Transnational Networks

A focus on global and transnational networks in explanations of rising right-wing populism around the world helps to address several of the shortcomings with other literatures. Unlike theories of economic globalization, it makes significant progress towards answering why right-wing populist movements have found electoral success in some countries but not others. Unlike cultural backlash explanations, it engages seriously with the role of political elites. And unlike political communication approaches, it reaches sufficiently far back in the causal chain to include the origins of the ideological messages and policy agendas that are used by politicians to prime, frame, and set the terms of debate. By putting the interactions and relationships among political elites under the microscope, it offers the greatest clarity about why a distinctive form of right-wing politics has emerged in so many different contexts.

Below the leader level, an interest in network variables and organizations has already yielded payoffs for making sense of the far right. Work on activist groups, for example, has highlighted that the number and skill of the grassroots membership matters (Art, 2011). If right-wing populist parties and candidates can recruit a large number of highly skilled people to work for them, they tend to be set up well for electoral success. Indeed, in spite of the simplicity of the theory and the risk of tautology, the ability of right-wing populists to grow their ranks with the right kinds of activists, and the electoral results that follow, varies in predictable ways across space and time. Across countries, scholarship has argued that deep roots (such as in veterans organizations, former authoritarian states, settler groups, gun clubs, and evangelical Christian churches) and destigmatization among mainstream parties and the news media are the key predictor variables of right-wing populist voting (Art, 2011; Loxton, 2021; Mayka and Smith, 2021; Skocpol and Tervo, 2020; Skocpol and Newman, 2023; Ternullo, 2024).

A new and exciting research agenda has also emerged contending that right-wing populism, especially in the Global South, has been strengthened and perhaps causally reinforced by the structure of contemporary social media networks (Gold and Peša, 2019; Romancini and Castilho, 2019). Arguing that social media facilitates right-wing populist movements by reducing the costs of organization, communication, and recruitment, the literature hypothesizes that for right-wing parties and candidates that have historically been strongly associated with elite actors, there may be powerful benefits to being able to build grassroots support online. The structure of the network allows a greater number of skilled activists to get involved without the level of commitment otherwise necessary under conditions of high stigmatization.

If organizations at the level of activists and on social media have made a difference in the rise of right-wing populism, it stands to reason that turning towards organizations among political elites might also be fruitful. At a very early stage of the causal chain, we argue that right-wing populism is likely the product of global and transnational networks among leaders themselves. Similar to how western European far right party leaders like Jean-Marie Le Pen developed and diffused a "master frame" beginning in the 1970s and 1980s and Geert Wilders learned from the mistakes of Pim Fortuyn more recently (Rydgren, 2005; de Lange and Art, 2011), this paper contends that right-wing populism in its current form emerged among incumbents learning from each other and acting as agents of change, with leadership on the international stage coming from unlikely places. Rather than originating from the U.S. president or other powerful leaders, or even cooperation between local actors and well-resourced diasporas in the United States (Asher and Mandelkern, 2025), it appears that figures like Jair Bolsonaro and Viktor Orban played a central part in the development of the rhetorical frameworks that have been subsequently adopted by a cohort of far right leaders. Working with think tanks, advocacy organizations, and media companies and using the organs of the state available to them as incumbents (Dezalay and Garth, 2002; Schimmelfennig, 2001; Ban, 2016; Keck and Sikkink, 1998), they defined the contours of right-wing populist ideology and helped to bring about its shared language.

Qualitative Analysis of the Network

While analysis of the speeches of right-wing populist presidents and prime ministers will allow us to test patterns of similarity and difference in the use of language and political ideas between pairs of right-wing leaders, providing quantified measures of certain kinds of transnational linkages among them, a broader and more multifaceted if less precise picture of these linkages can emerge from the historical record. We first use process tracing to examine the pattern of in-person visits among right-wing populist leaders, organizational ties across their movements, and resource sharing across international boundaries — including the resource of ideological messages. Using data from press releases, news coverage, and investigative reporting, we show that the far-right cohort including Viktor Orban, Donald Trump, Jair Bolsonaro, and Giorgia Meloni has used a decade of intensive personal interactions, institutional collaboration, and international meetings to forge an international movement of nationalist politics.

By way of these networked relationships, a core group within the set of right-wing populist leaders has played a disproportionate part in shaping the discursive and ideological content of each other’s campaigns and tenures in office, and their strategic coordination should be studied as plausibly an important part of the explanation for the wave of electoral success across the globe. Indeed, the timing and configurations of networked relationships observable through process tracing suggest intentionality and not just homophily. The evidence of sustained cooperation between leaders in meeting, building connections, and developing relationships raises the hypothesis that there may be parallel patterns in terms of shared work in identifying wedge issues, fine-tuning populist rhetoric, and developing right-wing policy agendas. We will offer an initial assessment of this hypothesis using quantitative analysis of text in the subsequent section.

We find evidence that the right-wing movement began as a set of relatively disconnected global actors, drawing inspiration from each other in moments but treating each other with the standard degree of caution and distance expected of leaders in a chaotic international order. However, Brazilian president Bolsonaro spent the window between 2018 and the start of the COVID pandemic working to build a closer and more collaborative network among these leaders and movements. When his standing in domestic and international politics was shadowed by the costs and turmoil of Brazil’s passage through the pandemic, Hungary’s Orban took on the role of international movement entrepreneurship that Bolsonaro had initially pioneered. The deliberate, traceable network-building activity of these leaders has given them more international prestige and historical relevance, and has left the contemporary far right with an organizationally and ideologically globalized infrastructure that makes it more robust to temporary local political setbacks.

Our search for causal process observations is guided by the construction of an original database of meetings between the leaders, building upon the existing Country & Organization Leader Travel (COLT) database in three ways (Moyer et al., 2025). First, we add bilateral and trilateral meetings that occurred on the sidelines of major international organization summits like annual sessions of the United Nations General Assembly or BRICS meetings. Second, we include meetings that took place when the leaders were out of office, all of which happened between 2021-2025 for Trump and after 2023 for Bolsonaro. We consider these contacts even though we are only systematically analyzing the rhetoric of leaders when they were in office because we suspect that they may have been important interactions that influenced the contents of Trump’s speeches since the beginning of his second term. Finally, whereas the COLT database stops at the end of 2023, we include meetings from 2024 and 2025.

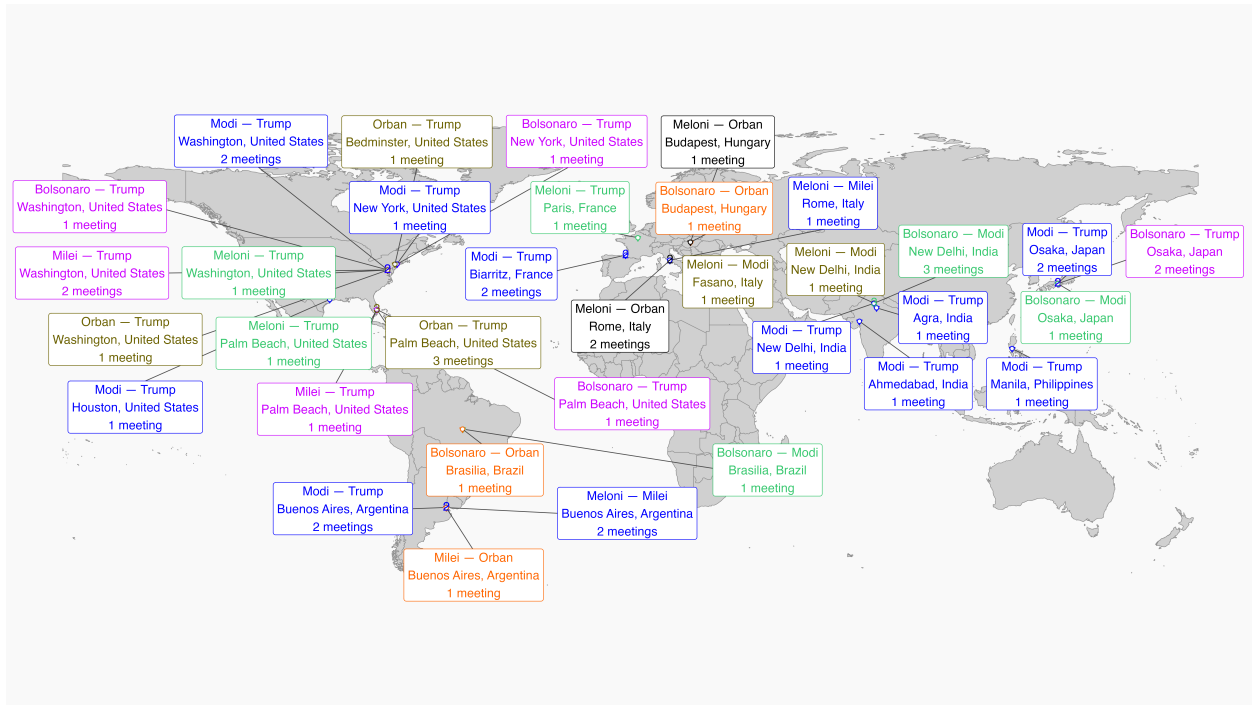


Figure 1: Meeting Locations by Leader Pair (colors identify leader pairs)

A Set of Relatively Disconnected Actors

The first recorded meetings between any of the six right-wing populist leaders under study took place in 2017, the year Donald Trump first became president. A surprise winner in the 2016 U.S. election who had upset establishment rivals, Trump entered the White House with deep divisions within his administration. When he hosted Modi in Washington for the first time in July 2017 and spoke with him again on the sidelines of the November 2017 ASEAN summit in the Philippines, there was little evidence of strategic coordination on distinctive political or policy grounds. Trump’s chief strategist Steve Bannon had celebrated Modi’s victory in 2014 as part of a connected global wave and remarked to colleagues that he viewed Trump and Modi as expressing the same nationalist impulses, but the meetings followed in the pattern of six previous meetings between Modi and former president Barack Obama and did not focus on recognizably right-wing populist issues (Landler and Harris, 2017; Office of the Press Secretary, 2017; Ayres, 2017). Centering on foreign and defense policy considerations related to countering the influence of China in the Indian Ocean and the South China Sea, the meetings could have been held between virtually any two American and Indian leaders. They were not venues for message sharing or policy agenda development beyond the articulation of long-standing shared geopolitical interests.

Even more indicative of the lack of networked relationships between the leaders, Orban was repeatedly rebuffed in his initial attempts to travel to the United States. Despite being the first foreign leader to endorse Trump, Orban was unable to secure a White House invitation for more than two years. Senior foreign policy officials like Secretary of State Mike Pompeo had concerns about Russian and Chinese influence in Hungary, and a bipartisan group of senators led by Jim Risch (R-ID) opposed his visit because of the country’s “downward democratic trajectory” (Novak and Kingsley, 2019; Lippman, Bayer and Meyer, 2019). Though Bannon called Orban “Trump before Trump” and reportedly met with the Hungarian prime minister and his aides in Budapest several times after departing the White House in August 2017, the first Trump administration continued the prevailing Obama administration policy of freezing out Orban until May 2019 (Krastev, 2018; Green, 2017; Szakacs, 2018). To break through, a former Republican congressman had to

work for 18 months as a lobbyist for Hungary, telling members of Congress, State Department officials, and White House staff that Orban was the European leader most aligned with Trump. A former Hungarian ambassador to the United States remarked that the delayed Oval Office audience was “much more difficult for Orban to get than people think ... It’s embarrassing for Orban.”

The Election of Bolsonaro and the Building of Linkages

Right-wing populist leaders began to forge markedly closer ties following the election of Jair Bolsonaro in 2018. Orban attended his inauguration in Brasilia and held bilateral talks with the newly elected president, focusing on “opportunities for international, economic, and political cooperation” ([About Hungary, 2019](#)). While a variety of leaders from across the ideological spectrum in Latin America attended, Orban was the only head of government from Europe to attend, testifying to an unusual affinity and burgeoning relationship between the two leaders ([Phillips, 2018b](#); [Walker, 2019](#)). Bolsonaro had previously told Orban in a congratulatory phone call that “Hungary is a country that suffered a lot from communism in the past,” whereas “the Brazilian people still don’t know what a dictatorship is” ([Phillips, 2018a](#)). Shortly after the inauguration, Eduardo Bolsonaro, a committee chair in the Chamber of Deputies, traveled to Budapest, where he met with Orban and they agreed to reject the first-ever intergovernmentally negotiated global migration compact ([Cabinet Office of the Prime Minister, 2019](#)). Orban’s visit was both preceded and followed by deepening contacts at the leader level and throughout the government that signaled close alignment in opposition to the ideological left and a range of domestic and international institutions.

Bolsonaro built upon his strong connection with Orban by making two successive trips to the United States in short order. Within a two-month span, Bolsonaro met with Trump in the Oval Office and returned to Texas, where he dined with Senator Ted Cruz (R-TX) ([Smith, 2019](#)). The trip to Washington was particularly eventful in establishing transnational linkages and encouraging message-borrowing. Trump told reporters he was “honored” by comparisons with Bolsonaro and observed that the Bolsonaro campaign “reminded people of our campaign,” and he applauded the Brazilian president for mimicking his language in attacking the news media, saying, “I’m very proud to hear the president use the term fake news” (?). In showering Bolsonaro with praise, Trump showed his awareness of the similarities between the two leaders and telegraphed his explicit approval, a powerful message from the famously transactional president. Bolsonaro had also visited the U.S. Chamber of Commerce the previous day, telling business leaders that “we want to have a great Brazil just like Trump wants to have a great America” (?). With the echoing of central themes, Bolsonaro made a conscious effort to associate himself with an American president with like-minded pro-business and anti-news media beliefs.

The obvious bond at the leader level during the Washington trip was reinforced by intensive networking between activists, intellectuals, and officials in the Trump and Bolsonaro orbits. During the visit, Bannon met with Eduardo Bolsonaro to watch a screening of a documentary about Brazilian right-wing populist intellectual Olavo de Carvalho, and the Brazilian president spoke to an audience of American right-wing populist “opinion formers” ([Schreckinger, 2019](#); [Phillips, 2019](#)). Matt Schlapp, head of the Conservative Political Action Conference (CPAC), attended and remarked that he was surprised by how closely the Brazilians in attendance were paying attention to political developments in the United States, observing that they could cite specific speeches from CPAC. “They’re starting to talk to each other,” Bannon hailed of the strengthening ties. “This is going to be very powerful” (?). Though Bannon was much incentivized to exaggerate as the founder of a new Brussels-based far-right political organization called The Movement, the visit marked a turning point in relations between far-right leaders worldwide. From the conversation about rhetorical emulation in the Oval Office to the exchange of ideological frameworks among mid-level actors, right-wing populist leaders, led by Bolsonaro, were starting to come into closer union.

Bolsonaro, the linchpin of the efforts, followed the visits to the United States with two additional contacts with Trump and two meetings with Modi, his first with the Indian prime minister. Each occurred at major international organization summits, which afforded the leaders the opportunity to develop greater familiarity and trust with each other and gain a sense of a shared agenda behind the scenes while publicly celebrating each other. At the 2019 G20 summit in Japan, Bolsonaro held bilateral talks with both Trump and Modi.

He spoke at a joint press conference with Trump, where the American president hailed Bolsonaro's election victory as "one of the greatest election wins anywhere in the world" (Lipton, 2019). His initial encounter with Modi was less remarkable and covered topics of known disagreement, as a Modi spokesman tweeted that the conversation focused on "cooperation in trade & investment, agriculture & bio-fuels in the context of climate change" (Press Trust of India, 2019b). Like Trump, Bolsonaro has minimized the scientific consensus on climate change (Watts, 2018; Londoño and Friedman, 2018; Caverni, 2018; Kaiser, 2019; Escobar, 2019). From the brief summary, Bolsonaro and Modi saw areas of shared interest, but they had not yet figured out a distinctive set of issues that they could enthusiastically embrace together.

At the annual meeting of the United Nations General Assembly, Bolsonaro made further progress with both Trump and Modi. In a 15-minute conversation at a cocktail party for visiting foreign leaders, Trump told Bolsonaro that he had liked his speech and wanted his speechwriters to adopt a similar rhetorical style. "If I had heard your speech before, I would have asked my advisors for a new one, better and firmer," Trump reportedly said (Rittner, 2019). Bolsonaro had attacked socialism and "politically correct" ideology, denounced the news media for "sensationalist attacks" about the Amazon wildfires, and concluded that "we are not here to erase nationalities and sovereignties" (Bolsonaro, 2019). Trump, for his part, criticized "globalism" and echoed that "the free world must embrace its national foundations. It must not attempt to erase them" (Borger, 2019). Even with Trump expressing a preference for Bolsonaro's version, the two speeches bore a striking resemblance and showed a right-wing populist worldview coming into focus. Globalists, understood to be left-leaning and politically correct, were positioned as the chief adversary against the patriotic and right-leaning nation. While Bolsonaro and Modi once again hewed closer to mainstream concerns when they met at the 2019 BRICS summit in Brazil, with Modi tweeting that they discussed "the economy, connectivity, and people-to-people ties," the Indian prime minister extended a prized invitation to Bolsonaro to be the honored guest at India's Republic Day celebrations (Modi, 2019; Press Trust of India, 2019a). Though Bolsonaro and Modi were not speaking in terms as similar as Bolsonaro and Trump, they were taking meaningful steps to strengthen their ties and build their relationship.

While Trump and Modi notably also developed a closer alliance in late 2019 and early 2020 through the spectacle of back-to-back megaevents, a "Howdy Modi" rally in Houston, Texas and a "Namaste Trump" rally in Ahmedabad, Gujarat, the trends in global travel would soon be interrupted by an exogenous shock: the COVID-19 pandemic (Kumar, 2019; Crowley, 2020; Holland and Pal, 2020; Abbas et al., 2020). Bolsonaro was visiting Florida when the extent of the crisis became clear in the United States. He had postponed a planned trip to Italy, Hungary, and Poland out of concern for the spread of the virus, but he dined with Trump at Mar-a-Lago, where he learned of the anti-malaria drug hydroxychloroquine as a potential cure to the disease. Twenty-two members of the Brazilian delegation later tested positive upon their return from the visit, which the former Brazilian health minister characterized as a "corona trip" (Kirkpatrick and Cabrera, 2020; Baker and Rogers, 2020; Picheta and Siad, 2020). The number of affected individuals provided a small window into the deepening association between the American and Brazilian governments under Trump and Bolsonaro. The parallels in American and Brazilian public health policymaking during the pandemic (Béland et al., 2021) also seemed to stem at least in part from Bolsonaro's belief, strengthened by Trump, that COVID-19 was easily curable and the leading medical science was untrustworthy. Yet Bolsonaro and the other right-wing populist incumbents paid a price for the pandemic, and only after the multi-year crisis subsided did the leaders regroup and begin meeting again. When they did, a new entrepreneur had taken up the mantle of international leadership in strengthening the emerging network's infrastructure.

Orban and the Strengthening of Network Infrastructure

The COVID-19 pandemic directly and indirectly brought many changes to global politics. It contributed to Trump's decisive loss in the 2020 U.S. election and his subsequent exile at Mar-a-Lago as a disgraced former president who had incited the January 6th attacks on the U.S. Capitol building. It also hurt the popularity of Bolsonaro and Modi, who were perceived to have mismanaged their responses with disastrous consequences. But Viktor Orban, who had long before stacked the deck of Hungarian democracy in his favor and quickly declared a "state of emergency," grew stronger. He positioned himself more centrally, not just

as a spokesman and model for “illiberal democracy” but also for a particular vision of the far right. Through his outreach to the defeated ex-presidents Trump and Bolsonaro to his encouragement of a new generation of leaders like Giorgia Meloni, Orbán played a larger role in the resurrection of right-wing populist resource sharing and message borrowing than its initial emergence. No longer viewed as the pariah that he was when Modi or Trump first took office, Orbán had been normalized, in part due to Bolsonaro’s decision to embrace him. From his outpost as prime minister of a small central European country, Orbán increasingly became seen as the model for right-wing populist governance worldwide.

Transnational linkages among the far right had long been more institutionalized in Europe than elsewhere because of the European Parliament and its incentives for forming supranational political groups (Lefkofridi and Katsanidou, 2018; McDonnell and Werner, 2020). It was in the broader context of this transnational far-right organizing that Orbán and Meloni, then a member of the Italian parliament, first met and began to formulate a shared agenda. The Hungarian prime minister traveled to Italy during the 2018 Italian parliamentary elections and returned soon after as an invited speaker of her party, the Brothers of Italy, an unusual appearance for a visiting leader (Hungary Today, 2021; Ádám Bráder, 2022). In his speech, Orbán remarked on the strangeness of a party from the larger and more populous country of Italy being so interested in Hungary but described “a model of political and state theory” under his leadership, including opposition to migration and “three pillars” of the family, the nation, and Christianity (Orbán, 2019). Meloni echoed the language in an interview with the Hungarian pro-government newspaper *Magyar Nemzet*, saying Orbán “is a role model” and crediting him with “standing up for the sovereignty and Christian identity of his nation” and “defending his country’s borders from mass immigration.” For Meloni, Orbán was “setting an example” on issues like national identity, religious identity, and immigration (Loretta, 2019; Cseresnyés, 2019). Meloni traveled to Hungary in 2020, when she repeated to the media, “I always feel at home among Hungarians . . . because with Viktor Orbán, we share the same vision and mission for Europe” (Nagy, 2022).

By 2021, Orbán and Meloni were engaged in talks about right-wing populist parties joining forces in the 2024 European elections. They met in Brussels, where they discussed their shared goal of unifying right-wing parties around “the traditional family model, a European community founded on strong nation states, as well as the continent’s common cultural and religious origins” (BAON, 2021; Ádám Bráder, 2022; Nagy, 2022). While Orbán eventually decided to keep Fidesz at an arm’s length, the meeting bore witness to the larger determination of Orbán and Meloni to work together and the common language of nationalism and cultural and religious conservatism that they were developing. The next month, the leaders of 16 far-right parties, including Orbán and Meloni, signed a similar letter declaring that “the cooperation of European nations should be based on tradition, respect for the culture and history of European states, [and] respect for Europe’s Judeo-Christian heritage” (Nagy, 2022). They resumed one-on-one talks a month later in Rome, speaking about making the European right “the largest political force in Europe again” and responding to the “threat of migration” (Magyar Nemzet, 2021; Nagy, 2022). With a well-defined agenda of family policy and migration policy coming into focus, Orbán and Meloni had forged a set of priorities that tied them together.

As Orbán was deepening his relationship with Meloni, who was elected prime minister of Italy in 2022, he was also reengaging Trump and Bolsonaro, working to rehabilitate their images and aid their electoral fortunes. He was the first foreign leader to visit Trump during his interregnum, just as he had been the first foreign leader to endorse Trump in the 2016 U.S. election. While Trump had been slow to embrace Orbán during his first administration, calling the Hungarian prime minister “probably, like me, a little bit controversial,” as a private citizen Trump eagerly backed him, endorsing him ahead of the 2022 Hungarian election as a “strong leader” who has “done a powerful and wonderful job in protecting Hungary, stopping illegal immigration, [and] creating jobs” (Goldmacher, 2022). Orbán would eventually visit Trump four times when he was out of office, bypassing incumbent President Joe Biden and coordinating on the politics of the Russia-Ukraine war (Waterfield, 2022; Richards and Luce, 2024; Holmes and Millman, 2024; Spike and Colvin, 2024; Samuels, 2024; Losonczi, 2024).

Orbán would go even further with Bolsonaro. After finally hosting the Brazilian president in 2022, when

Bolsonaro called Orban “my brother” and used the Italian fascist slogan of “God, homeland, family, and freedom” (Gielow, 2022; Spike, 2022), the Orban government reportedly made an explicit offer to help Bolsonaro’s reelection campaign (Marchesini, 2022; Nicas et al., 2024). Bolsonaro narrowly lost the 2023 Brazilian election, but he has since turned to Orban for assistance in navigating his legal troubles related to the January 8th attacks on federal government buildings in Brasilia by his supporters. Most notably, Bolsonaro hid at the Hungarian embassy for two days to avoid arrest following the confiscation of his passport, explaining “I have a circle of friends with some leaders. They’re worried,” (Nicas et al., 2024; Gadelha, 2024). Recognizing that the fall of Trump and Bolsonaro could hurt his ideological project, Orban worked to reverse their downward trajectory and lend them legitimacy by meeting with them and extending political and legal favors.

Orban’s outreach to Trump and Bolsonaro after the pandemic was also increasingly bolstered by and channeled through a web of think tanks, advocacy organizations, and networks of activists and officials seeking to advance global right-wing populism. The institution-building, enthusiastically supported by Orban, ensured that when Trump returned to the campaign trail, he did so advancing a more uncompromising and distilled version of his ideological project. “Orban put all his cards on Trump’s victory,” said a source close to the Hungarian government (Garamvolgyi and May, 2024). The work helped to produce a common toolbox of strategies for the far right around the world. Said one Hungarian think tank official, “As left-wing parties have been helping each other for the past hundred years, with policies and also sometimes with campaign tactics, it is quite possible that conservatives from across the globe from India to Europe to America could help each other with some of the best practices in campaigns as well” (Garamvolgyi and May, 2024).

Arguably the most visible manifestation of transnational organizing on the far right has been the proliferation of right-wing populist conferences, especially CPAC, an annual gathering of American conservatives since 1974. The internationalization of CPAC, including its willingness to feature foreign leaders at gatherings in the United States and its rapid expansion around the world, has created a key venue for right-wing populist leaders to interact. Orban, for example, was traveling to Dallas at the invitation of CPAC when he first reengaged Trump in 2022, and shortly after his election in 2023, Milei met Trump for the first time at CPAC in Washington (Waterfield, 2022; Warren, 2022; Smith, 2022; Vigdor, 2022). Beyond the United States, CPAC held its first international event in Japan in 2017, and began to take a more distinctively right-wing populist turn in 2019 with an event in Brazil emceed by Eduardo Bolsonaro (CPAC, 2023, 2024; Zanini, 2019). Yet following a high-profile week of broadcasts from Budapest by Fox News television host Tucker Carlson in 2021 (Thorpe, 2021; Smith, 2021; Novak and Grynbaum, 2021), it was the start of annual meetings in Hungary in 2022 that cemented the new era of intensifying ties between CPAC and right-wing populism across the globe (CBS News, 2022, 2025). “We have to take the institutions back in Washington and Brussels,” Orban said at the inaugural event. “We must find allies in one another and coordinate the movements of our troops” (Orbán, 2022). Whereas American conservatives had once eyed Orban suspiciously for his ties with Russia and China and his part in democratic backsliding, the Hungarian prime minister had come to occupy a central position in one of their oldest and most important organizations.

CPAC is not the only conference of right-wing populists that has reached across borders — the National Conservatism conference has brought conservatives in the United States and western Europe into closer orbit (Green, 2019; Montlake, 2025), and the Madrid Forum has targeted anti-socialists in Latin America and southern Europe (Latin America News, 2021; EFE, 2020; González, Gortázar and Molina, 2021; Carvajal, 2020; no, 2020) — but behind the scenes, cooperation between the leaders and their movements has gone even deeper in less visible ways. Conservative commentator Rod Dreher revealed as much in a 2022 interview, when he shared that a press secretary for Florida Governor Ron DeSantis confirmed “Oh yeah, we were watching the Hungarians” when they passed the state’s so-called “Don’t Say Gay” law (Beauchamp, 2022). Dreher worked for the Danube Institute, a government-funded Hungarian think tank that has received \$1.64 million to fund foreign projects (Zubor, 2024; Garamvolgyi and May, 2024). The Danube Institute enjoys a particularly close relationship with the Heritage Foundation, the authors of Project 2025. It has hosted visiting researchers from Heritage, and Heritage president Kevin Roberts has declared, “I am proud to call Viktor Orban a friend and ally, and I am proud of the strong relationship between Heritage and the Danube

Institute . . . We are working alongside conservatives around the world to end the globalist era,” ([Garamvolgyi and May, 2024](#)). Though interactions between mid-level activists have provided the intellectual foundation of the partnership, the regular communication has extended to the highest level. According to a source close to the Hungarian Embassy, Orban and his closest advisors “frequently exchange text messages with high-level Republican politicians,” including Vice President J.D. Vance ([Garamvolgyi and May, 2024](#)). Vance has been invited to Budapest, met with Hungarian officials in Washington, and attended a closed-door meeting at the Hungarian Embassy, all with the goal of “building a network of people Orban can contact directly” ([Garamvolgyi and May, 2024](#)). The web of ties, laid by exchanges among think tanks and reinforced by in-person contacts between leaders, has become so dense that Hungary today is one of only a few countries with no registered foreign lobbyists.

Though the dynamic between Orban and Trump has driven much of the networking between right-wing populists, especially since Bolsonaro left office, Meloni has been an active collaborator on most issues, and Milei has made a dramatic entrance onto the scene, showcasing the broad reach of global far-right organizing. First, Meloni has embraced travel to meet with right-wing populist leaders around the world. She has visited India twice ([Government, 2023](#); [of India, 2023](#)), met with Milei six times ([Government, 2024a](#); [Times, 2024](#); [Government, 2024c,b](#); [Bubola, 2024](#); [Government, 2025](#)) and adopted a five-year action plan “based on shared values and deep historical and cultural ties” ([Government, 2025](#)), and was one of the few world leaders to attend Trump’s inauguration, along with Milei ([Roth, 2025](#)). Responding to criticism from opposition parties and in the news media, she has made an explicit defense of her meetings with right-wing populist figures. “When Bill Clinton and Tony Blair created the global leftist liberal network in the 90s, they were called statesmen. Today, when Trump, Meloni, Milei, or maybe Modi talk, they are called a threat to democracy,” she observed ([MSN, 2025](#); [Right Side Broadcasting Network, 2025](#)).

Milei, likewise, has been connected with his counterparts through frequent meetings and appearances at global far-right conferences. For example, in addition to meeting with Meloni six times and attending Trump’s inauguration, he has traveled to the United States to meet with Trump four times ([Licon, 2024](#); [Davies, 2024](#); [Herald, 2025](#); [Bubola and Politi, 2025](#)), and he has spoken to CPAC twice in Washington. Orban and Bolsonaro, as a private citizen, also traveled to Buenos Aires for his inauguration, a sign of his strong linkages to right-wing populists ([Nicas et al., 2024](#)). Finally, he has formed an especially close relationship with tech entrepreneur Elon Musk. He has met with Musk on three separate occasions and famously gave Musk the chainsaw that the former Trump advisor and Trump donor wielded on stage at CPAC in promotion of his aggressive cost-cutting efforts at the Department of Government Efficiency (DOGE) ([Debre \(2024\)](#); [Caruso-Cabrera \(2024\)](#); [Otterbein and Jacobs \(2025\)](#)).

Implications

We see from considering the historical ties among right-wing national leaders that there is evidence in favor of the view that there has been a deliberate strategy of network construction. The pattern of meetings and personal connections suggests that network building was not initially a strong feature of the movement, and that it came into prominence with the election of, and perhaps as an initiative of, Brazilian president Jair Bolsonaro in 2018. Bolsonaro appears to have played a central and, arguably, globally disproportionate role relative to Brazil’s political and economic influence in the far-right network until his fortunes were disrupted by the COVID pandemic, at which point the evidence suggests that Hungary’s Victor Orban stepped in as the network’s hub. The reason why these actors from relatively peripheral countries played central roles in the movement is not entirely clear, although it makes sense that they would have unusual cost-benefit calculations that might favor bearing the costs of organization because this might lead them to receive extra attention, prestige, and influence from other world leaders that might otherwise be difficult to access.

This analysis has focused largely on the patterns of meetings and has not the textual or ideological content of speeches given by the leaders in these networks. It makes sense to ask whether, if our analysis is correct, there is a pattern of verbal borrowing and ideological similarity that mirrors the joint occurrence and timing of meetings and organizational connections. While this could be done to some extent with case-study analysis, the overall number of speeches involved is substantial, and the range of potential ideological themes and

rhetorical devices to be studied is extraordinary. It would be difficult to structure a qualitative study that covered the terrain without engaging in undo selectivity. As a result, we will pivot to quantitative text-as-data techniques for this phase of the research. Specifically, we will use these tools to explore the degree of similarity across leaders’ use of themes and rhetorical devices, both to gauge its similarity to the general findings of this section and specifically to evaluate whether Bolsonaro and Orban retain their disproportionate centrality.

Speech corpus and thematic analysis

We assemble a corpus of public speeches for each leader that covers their full tenure in national executive office. For every leader in our sample, we scrape all available speech transcripts from their official websites (for example, the presidential or prime ministerial site and associated press offices) for the entire period in which they held office. For leaders operating in parliamentary systems, we complement the material from official government websites with parliamentary speeches, drawn from the official transcript service of the national legislature. This yields, for each leader, a comprehensive record of their formal, on-the-record public communication while in office. Where websites provide the same speech in multiple languages, we retain only the version in the leader’s primary governing language and drop translated duplicates. We also remove obvious non-speech material (e.g. brief ceremonial greetings, press release boilerplate, purely technical notices), so that the corpus consists of substantive political speeches suitable for semantic modeling.

For the semantic representation, we embed every document with the paraphrase-multilingual-mpnet-base-v2 sentence-transformer (Reimers and Gurevych, 2019). This model is trained for multilingual semantic similarity and maps texts in different languages into a shared vector space, so that paraphrases and closely related passages lie near one another regardless of language. We first segment each speech into shorter units (roughly paragraph-to-page length), remove stopwords in the relevant languages, and then encode the resulting text segments into numerical vectors. These document embeddings provide the input both for topic modeling and for all downstream comparisons.

To extract themes within each leader, we fit separate BERTopic models to the corpus of that leader (Grotenendorst, 2022). Each model takes as input the precomputed embeddings and a bag-of-words representation (unigrams and bigrams after stopwords removal). BERTopic uses UMAP to reduce the embedding space and HDBSCAN to cluster documents into topics, and then applies a class-based TF-IDF scheme to derive word distributions for each topic from the bag-of-words. For every document, we retain its full vector of topic probabilities and its most likely topic label, along with a short human-readable topic representation constructed from the top c -TF-IDF words. These leader-specific topic models form the basis for all subsequent clustering and similarity analyses.

To compare leaders in a common semantic space, we first represent each BERTopic topic by a topic embedding. For each leader and topic, we take the document embeddings and compute a probability-weighted average, using the topic-document posterior probabilities from BERTopic as weights. This yields one topic vector per topic and leader. We then compute cosine similarity between every pair of topics belonging to different leaders and store these values in leader-pair-specific similarity matrices. Because the BERTopic models yield a large number of fine-grained topics per leader, we group topics into coarser clusters for the cross-leader analyses. For each leader, we run an additional k -means clustering algorithm on that leader’s topic embeddings, where the number of clusters k grows with corpus size ($k = \max\{2, \lfloor n_{\text{docs}}/200 \rfloor\}$). This produces a partition of topics into within-leader clusters that bundle together semantically related topics. For each cluster, we define a short textual representation for interpretability by taking the most frequent BERTopic label among its member topics, splitting it into component words, removing multilingual stopwords (English, Italian, Spanish, Portuguese, Hungarian) and numbers, and keeping the remaining distinct words.

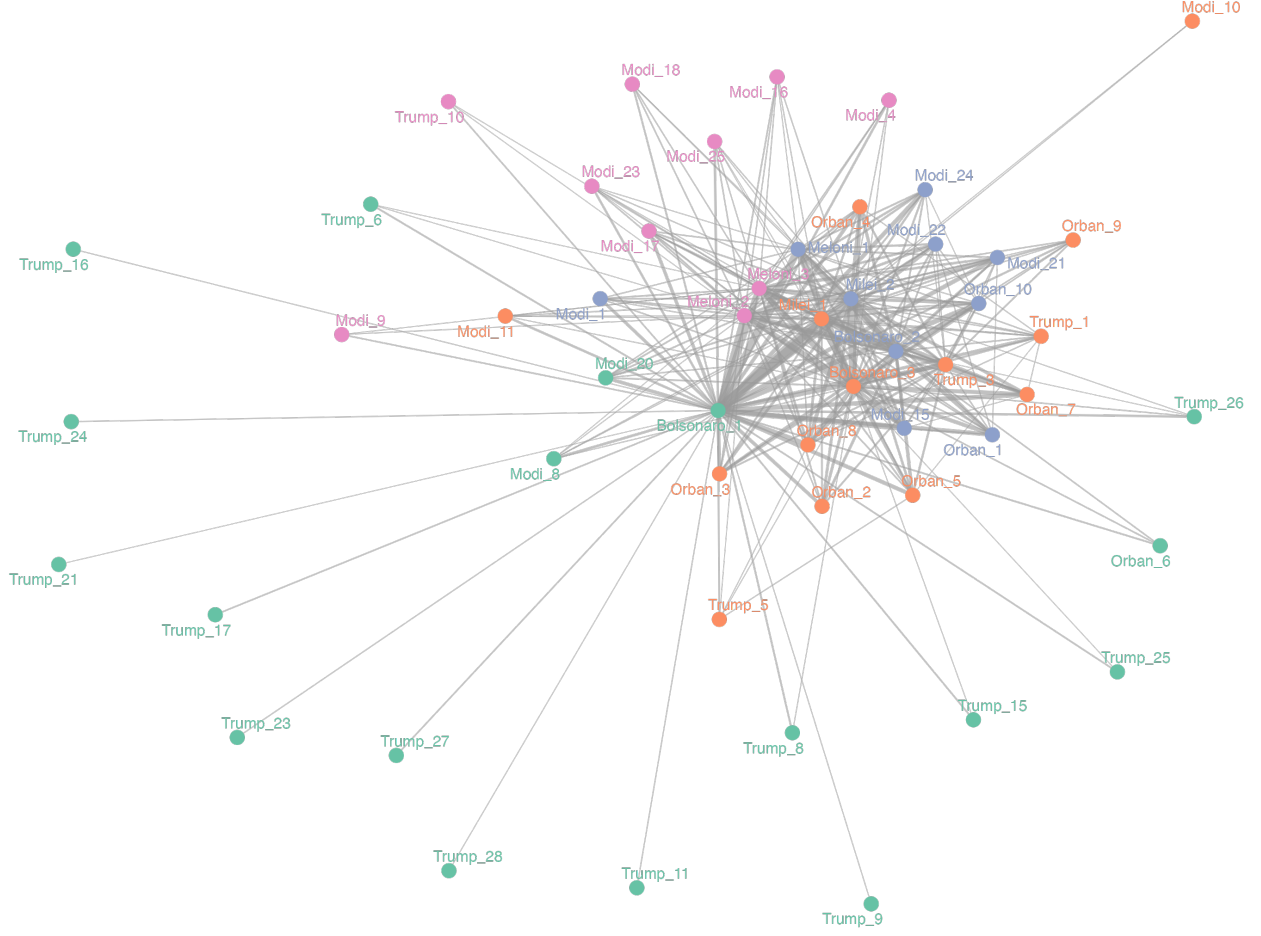


Figure 2: Louvain communities of topic clusters. Nodes are topic clusters within leaders. Edges are cosine similarity (85% and above). Colours are Louvain communities on the cluster similarity network.

Network structure of shared themes

The similarity network in Figure 3 takes the leader-specific topic clusters described above as its nodes and connects them with edges where there is sufficiently high cross-leader semantic similarity. Concretely, for every pair of clusters belonging to different leaders we compute the cosine similarity between their topic embeddings and retain only the strongest cross-leader links, here defined as those above the 85th percentile of the observed similarity distribution. The resulting undirected, weighted graph captures those thematic clusters that are not merely idiosyncratic to a single leader but form part of a shared cross-national repertoire. We then apply Louvain community detection to this graph, using edge weights as the measure of tie strength, which yields a small number of dense communities of clusters that cohere around transnational themes. All speeches across each leaders full tenure in executive office enter this construction, so the network summarizes the structure of shared rhetoric over the entire period rather than a single episode.

The community structure and centrality patterns in this graph line up closely with the qualitative picture developed in the previous section. Visually, the Bolsonaro_1 node sits at the heart of the network, with multiple thick edges to clusters belonging to other leaders. This impression is confirmed by the centrality statistics in Table 1: Bolsonaros clusters are few in number but extremely central, with the highest average eigenvector centrality and by far the highest average betweenness centrality among all leaders. Substantively,

Table 1: Leader-level structural statistics on the cross-leader topic-cluster similarity network.

Statistic	Bolsonaro	Milei	Meloni	Orban	Modi	Trump
Number of clusters	3.00	2.00	3.00	10.00	16.00	18.00
Mean eigenvector centrality	0.81	0.76	0.61	0.32	0.22	0.10
Mean betweenness centrality	0.29	0.03	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00
Number of communities spanned	3.00	2.00	2.00	3.00	4.00	3.00
Share of clusters in dominant community	0.33	0.50	0.67	0.70	0.44	0.78

this implies that Bolsonaros core thematic cluster is not just well connected to other highly connected clusters, but also lies on many of the shortest cross-leader paths that link otherwise distant parts of the graph. In other words, Bolsonaros rhetoric occupies a structurally privileged position in the shared semantic space, consistent with the earlier process-tracing evidence that he played an entrepreneurial role in knitting together a previously loose set of far-right leaders.

By contrast, Modi and Trump appear relatively peripheral in the pooled similarity network. Both have many clusters, but their average eigenvector and betweenness centralities are low, and most of Trumps clusters in particular fall inside a single community with few bridging ties. This is exactly what we would expect if much of their rhetoric remains domestically oriented, with only selected subsets overlapping the shared transnational repertoire defined by Bolsonaro, Orban, Meloni, and (more recently) Milei. Orban occupies an intermediate position: his average eigenvector centrality is moderate, and his clusters are concentrated in a small number of communities, suggesting a distinctive but less brokerage-heavy role in the semantic network than Bolsonaros. This pattern fits our qualitative account in which Orban gradually becomes a central supplier of a coherent ideological package, while Bolsonaros clusters play a disproportionate role in linking that package to other leaders rhetoric.

The community assignments themselves also speak to the existence of transnational thematic blocks. Because each Louvain community typically contains clusters from multiple leaders, the communities can be read as shared frames or issue bundles that circulate across countries rather than leader-specific idiolects. That Bolsonaro, Meloni, Orban, and Milei each span multiple communities, while still having a substantial share of their clusters anchored in a dominant community, suggests that they help to populate several overlapping but distinct segments of this common repertoire. Trump and Modi, in turn, plug into these blocks more selectively, reinforcing the picture from the meeting data that they are important allies but not the primary architects of the global far-right message.

To examine how these transnational communities of themes evolve over time, we replicate the same construction in a second figure that splits the similarity network into two periods. Using the existing topic embeddings and within-leader clusters, we recompute cross-leader cosine similarities separately for all speeches delivered before 2021 and for those from 2021 onward, apply the same 85th-percentile edge threshold within each period, and run Louvain community detection on the resulting graphs. For comparability, we fix node positions with a single FruchtermanReingold layout computed on the union of pre- and post-2021 edges, and then plot the two period-specific networks side by side (Pre-2021 and 2021 and later), varying only the edges and community assignments. This yields a pair of panels that make it possible to trace shifts in the structure and centrality of cross-leader thematic linkages across the COVID-19 era and its political aftermath.

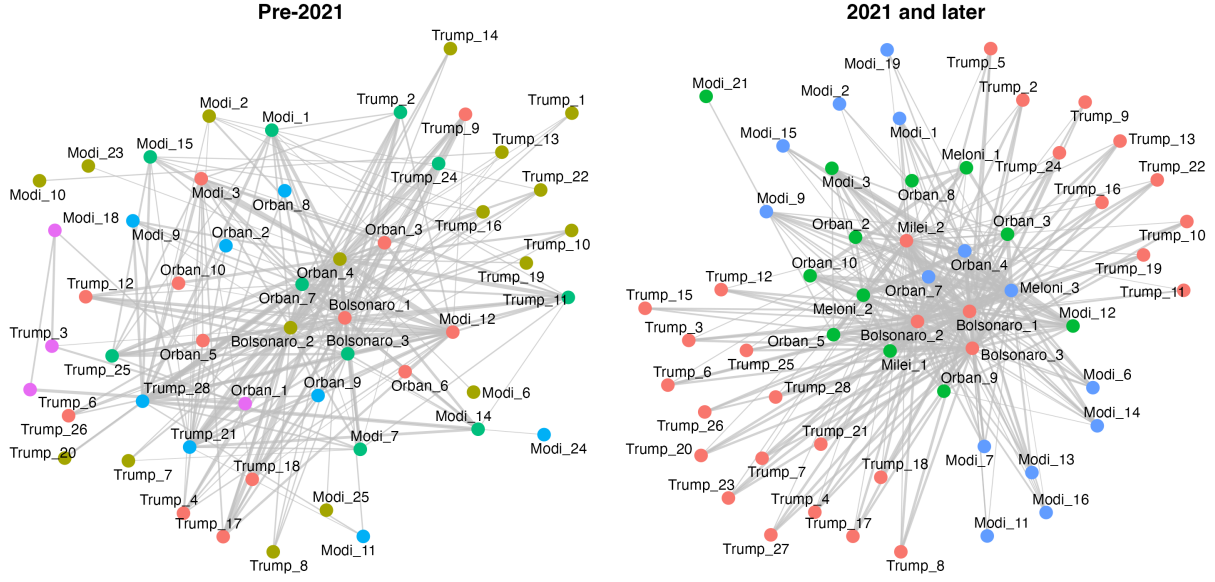


Figure 3: Louvain communities of topic clusters, before and after 2020. Nodes are topic clusters within leaders. Edges are cosine similarity (85% and above). Colours are Louvain communities on the cluster similarity network.

Taken together, the time-split networks in Figure 3 and the corresponding leader-level statistics show a mild thickening but much clearer restructuring of the shared thematic space after 2021, rather than a dramatic expansion. The pre-2021 network already contains a substantial number of cross-leader ties (52 nodes and 213 edges), and its density is 0.161. In the later period the number of clusters and cross-leader links both increase (to 56 nodes and 264 edges), and density rises slightly to 0.171, a change of about six percent. This points to a network that was already fairly well-knit in the late 2010s, but becomes somewhat more tightly integrated as additional leaders and themes enter the system.

Table 2: Leader-level structural statistics on the pre-2021 cross-leader topic-cluster similarity network.

Statistic	Bolsonaro	Orban	Trump	Modi
Number of clusters	3.00	10.00	24.00	15.00
Mean eigenvector centrality	0.86	0.31	0.30	0.27
Mean betweenness centrality	0.09	0.06	0.01	0.01
Number of communities spanned	2.00	5.00	5.00	5.00
Share of clusters in dominant community	0.67	0.40	0.29	0.33

Across both periods, Bolsonaro’s clusters remain structurally pivotal, and their importance increases rather than fading once he leaves office. In the pre-2021 network, Bolsonaro already has the highest mean eigenvector centrality and clearly outpaces the other leaders on average betweenness. After 2021, his average eigenvector centrality rises further and his mean betweenness more than doubles, even as Milei, Meloni, and a denser set of Orban clusters enter the graph. Substantively, this pattern is consistent with a narrative in which Bolsonaro acts as an early political entrepreneur for the contemporary far right: the thematic repertoire that crystallizes around his speeches continues to sit at the centre of the cross-leader network and to connect otherwise distant parts of it, even when he is no longer in office. Rather than Bolsonaro’s influence being a short-lived artefact of his single term, the time-split network suggests a lasting legacy in which other leaders continue to speak through frames that he helped to assemble.

Table 3: Leader-level structural statistics on the post-2021 cross-leader topic-cluster similarity network.

Statistic	Bolsonaro	Milei	Meloni	Orban	Modi	Trump
Number of clusters	3.00	2.00	3.00	8.00	14.00	26.00
Mean eigenvector centrality	0.98	0.76	0.51	0.42	0.30	0.22
Mean betweenness centrality	0.23	0.00	0.04	0.02	0.00	0.00
Number of communities spanned	1.00	2.00	2.00	2.00	2.00	1.00
Share of clusters in dominant community	1.00	0.50	0.67	0.75	0.79	1.00

The comparison of community structure before and after 2021 also lines up closely with the historical account. Before 2021, the similarity graph is partitioned into five communities, and each leaders clusters are spread thinly across them. Trump and Modi in particular have low average centralities and their clusters are scattered across multiple communities, with no single block clearly dominating their rhetoric. Visually, this produces a more fragmented thematic landscape in which cross-leader communities are numerous and only weakly associated with particular leaders. After 2021, the network contracts into three denser communities and clusters become much more sharply grouped by leader. Bolsonaro, Trump, and Modi now share a single community that contains all of Bolsonaros clusters and a dominant share of Trumps and Modis, while Orbans clusters are more heavily concentrated in distinct communities that run largely parallel to, rather than fully overlapping with, this BolsonaroTrumpModi block. Milei and Meloni enter directly into this consolidated structure, slotting into communities that already contain Bolsonaro and Orban clusters, rather than forming separate, idiosyncratic islands.

These temporal shifts are hard to reconcile with a story of purely parallel, domestically driven evolution. Instead, they reinforce the qualitative picture of an initially loose set of right-wing incumbents that gradually converge on a shared, transnational repertoire of themes. In the early period, Bolsonaro is already unusually central but operates in a more variegated community structure in which Trump and Modi remain comparatively peripheral and Orbans clusters are dispersed. In the later period, the network both tightens and polarizes: Bolsonaros rhetoric becomes an even more dominant hub linking U.S., Indian, and Latin American clusters; Orban occupies a more clearly demarcated thematic position that underpins his role as an ideological supplier; and new entrants such as Meloni and Milei attach themselves to these existing blocks rather than carving out entirely new ones. The time-split community graphs therefore provide quantitative support for the claim that Bolsonaros entrepreneurial role left a durable imprint on the shared language of the global far right, and that Orbans subsequent institution-building helped to stabilize this repertoire into a small number of recognizable transnational frames.

Conclusion

Against the backdrop of a multidisciplinary literature about the rise of the far right that has substantially focused on single-country studies, with some cross-country studies that explore the role of shared causes as explanations of the global trend toward far-right movements, we have attempted to contribute to the much smaller collection of research that directs attention to the far right as a coordinated, transnational social and political movement. Our findings point toward a few key conclusions.

First, our analysis of meetings and organization-building among far-right national leaders suggests that there is not a single time-invariant pattern of transnational dependence among far-right movements. Early developments in the current wave of far-right mobilization may well be best explained by national factors as well as by national responses to shared global causes, such as economic shocks, globalization, immigration trends, conflict, and so forth. During this period, there is little sign of coordination among far-right leaders, who act toward each other with the standard diplomatic behavior of heads of state but show no favoritism.

Much changes after the election of Jair Bolsonaro, with a key turning point at the end of 2018 or the beginning of 2019. Around this time, Bolsonaro takes an entrepreneurial role in organizing far-right heads of state into a closer trans-national network of friendship and coordination, marking a temporal turning point

when the movement develops an interdependent character. This persists to the present, although the central leadership role is taken over by Victor Orban when Bolsonaro's attention is distracted by Brazil's COVID crisis and eventually his leadership position is lost in the next presidential election.

Both phases of our analysis (the pattern of meetings and organization building, and the network of linguistic similarity among presidential speeches) support this hypothesis that Bolsonaro and Orban — a pair of leaders from countries would typically be expected to fall at the periphery of most transnational networks, especially among conservative and far-right actors that attach no normative weight to representation for the marginalized — have disproportionately central roles in right-wing networks in recent years. We interpret these roles as evidence for these presidents' influence. Although other interpretations might be possible, reading the evidence as showing these presidents' influence cleanly accounts for both the pattern of meetings and also the network of linguistic similarity in a coherent way that fits the picture better than any other theory we can find.

It seems reasonable to believe that these leaders might benefit disproportionately from taking on the work and other costs involved with assuming a leadership role in organizing the far right, since there may be few existing international organizational spaces or other transnational networks in which they are situated as close, intimate allies with the president of the United States. At the same time, this cannot be a full explanation; why does transnationalization have to wait for Bolsonaro's election, rather than the much earlier election of Narendra Modi, for example? While Modi would arguably face a similar cost-benefit structure compared to Bolsonaro, there are no doubt other reasons why he did not take a significant entrepreneurial role in transnationalizing the far right, while Bolsonaro did. The explanatory structure behind the timing and personalities involved in this transition would be a rich area for future exploration.

Regardless of the final explanatory model that emerges for the timing and decision-making behind the transnationalization of the far right, however, the patterns of transnational interconnection demonstrated in this analysis remain visible and analytically important. Scholars should refrain from treating the far right as a series of single-country phenomena or as a collection of statistically independent national trials for evaluating hypotheses. For a substantial part of the current far-right era, our data show, the movement is interconnected, interdependent, and truly global. There are profound and fascinating political ironies about a globalized movement of anti-globalist nationalists, but that is the reality which we must face.

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